

The old laws for delinquent debts seem harsh and unnecessarily cruel to us today, and perhaps they were. But the principles behind them were sound and just. The laws assumed that nobody was forced to borrow money; they borrowed money voluntarily. The lender extended honor (money), and the borrower represented himself as trustworthy. Thus the punishment for defaulting on a debt was actually more severe than for theft because it was considered a breach of trust.

2: Borrowing is permitted in Scripture

Many books have been written about handling money from a biblical viewpoint, many seminars have been taught, and there is no shortage of websites for reference. Some well-intentioned Christian teachers have taken the position that all borrowing is prohibited according to God's Word and that, consequently, Christians should not be involved in any borrowing or lending. Almost without exception, the biblical reference such teachers use to support their position is, "Let no debt remain outstanding, except the continuing debt to love one another, for he who loves his fellowman has fulfilled the law" (Romans 13:8).

I wish it were that simple, but it isn't. When I first came across Romans 13:8 in my study on finances, I thought, "Aha! Here is the justification for telling Christians to get rid of all credit, especially Christians who have misused it." But then I found myself in a quandary. If God, through the apostle Paul, intended to tell His people that all borrowing was prohibited, why are there New Testament Scriptures instructing men to repay what they borrow? That would be like prohibiting theft and then giving detailed instructions in how to invest stolen money. Obviously, that's ridiculous, which is why in the Bible you don't find principles regarding the handling of stolen goods.

Of course, God may have decided that it was time for His people to become totally debt-free, and thus in the New Testament changed the rules that had previously held true concerning indebtedness. But only those two alternatives exist: Either God changed the rules for